

SANDGROUSE

Sand-coloured plumage camouflages these birds in their desert habitats, where they are well adapted for living in an extremely dry environment.

With their rounded body and short legs, sandgrouse might be mistaken for partridges until they take flight, darting quickly and acrobatically in the air. These birds, the Pterocliiformes, are found in arid areas of Asia, Africa, Madagascar, and southern Europe. They are not related to the subarctic grouse species but are more closely related to pigeons.

Sandgrouse have long pointed wings and all species have cryptic plumage – mottled on the back, but often boldly marked with brown or white stripes or blotches on the head and underparts. They are

sociable birds that gather in flocks to make early morning, or sometimes evening, forays to drinking holes, often travelling considerable distances. They feed exclusively on seeds.

WATER CARRIERS

Sandgrouse breed during the rainy season to take advantage of seed harvests. Their nest is nothing more than shallow depression on the ground. Both parents incubate and care for their young. Remarkably, the males supply water to their chicks, which are normally raised far from water sources. The male's belly feathers soak up and retain moisture when the bird visits a drinking hole. Back at the nest, the chicks drink from the parent's soaked feathers.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	PTEROCLIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	16



Namaqua sandgrouse drink at a watering hole. Like all sandgrouse, they gather in large flocks to confuse predators.

PALLAS'S SANDGROUSE

Syrrhaptes paradoxus
F: Pteroclididae

One of two C. Asian sandgrouse, this large species has feathered toes, a long tail, and a long flight feather on each wing.

barred buff plumage

30–41 cm
12–16 in

long, pointed tail

25–28 cm
10–11 in

black and white bands on forecrown (male only)

DOUBLE-BANDED SANDGROUSE

Pterocles bicinctus
F: Pteroclididae

A bird of southern African savanna and open woodland, this is one of several sandgrouse species in which the males have distinctive belly stripes.

white-barred wings

black breast band

24–26 cm
9½–10 in

CHESTNUT-BELLIED SANDGROUSE

Pterocles exustus
F: Pteroclididae

With a range that extends from Senegal to Kenya, and east as far as India, this bird of open desert gathers in huge flocks.

31–33 cm
12–13 in

27–30 cm
10½–12 in

CROWNED SANDGROUSE

Pterocles coronatus
F: Pteroclididae

This yellow-throated sandgrouse is found from the stony desert of the Sahara to Pakistan. It can tolerate high temperatures and even brackish water.

LICHTENSTEIN'S SANDGROUSE

Pterocles lichtensteinii
F: Pteroclididae

This small bird is less gregarious than other species of sandgrouse. It inhabits bushy scrubland, and semi-desert regions from N. and E. Africa to Pakistan.